风筝

在潍坊过的一个夏天

The Kite Maker of Weifang

A summer in China's kite city

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 七月，学校放假了。小雪[†]今年十二岁，家在北京。这个夏天，爸爸妈妈工作都很忙，就把她送到了山东[‡]潍坊[§]的爷爷家。小雪一点儿也不想去。她觉得，在爷爷家过两个月，简直比上课还难过。

无聊[¶]的夏天

2 爷爷住在一个老房子里，房子不大，前面有一个小院子。家里没有电脑，网也很慢。小雪每天坐在院子里看手机，可是手机上的东西总是看不了几分钟就停了。“爷爷，这里太无聊了！”小雪说。爷爷笑了笑，没说什么，只是回到他的小屋子里，关上了门。

3 爷爷的小屋子，小雪还没进去过。每天早上，爷爷一吃完饭就进去，到晚上才出来。有一天，小雪实在太无聊了，就推开了那个门。

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† 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
‡ 山东 *Shāndōng* Shandong Province
§ 潍坊 *Wéifāng* Weifang, a city in Shandong
¶ 无聊 *wúliáo* boring

In July, school broke up for the holidays. Xiaoxue was twelve that year, and her home was in Beijing. That summer her parents were both busy at work, so they sent her to her grandfather's home in Weifang, in Shandong. Xiaoxue didn't want to go at all. As far as she was concerned, two months at Grandpa's would be even worse than being in class. 1

A Boring Summer

Grandpa lived in an old house. It wasn't big, and it had a little courtyard in front. There was no computer, and the internet was very slow. Every day Xiaoxue sat in the courtyard looking at her phone, but whatever she watched always stopped after a few minutes. "Grandpa, it's so boring here!" said Xiaoxue. Grandpa just smiled and said nothing. He went back into his little room and shut the door. 2

Xiaoxue had never been inside Grandpa's little room. Every morning, as soon as he finished breakfast, Grandpa went in, and he didn't come out until evening. One day Xiaoxue was so bored she couldn't stand it, and she pushed the door open. 3

3 她一下就站住了：屋子里简直像一个商店！墙上、桌子上、地上，到处都是风筝[†]。有红色的鱼，有黄色的龙，有蓝色的鸟，还有一只很大的鸟，眼睛好像正在看着她。桌子上放着很多很细[‡]的竹条[§]、几张纸和一些颜色。

4 “这些都是您做的？”小雪[¶]问。“都是我做的。”爷爷说，“我在风筝厂工作了四十年，退休以后，还是每天做。”“您做这么多，卖吗？”“不卖，送人。”爷爷说，“潍坊[*]人都喜欢风筝。从1984年开始，这里每年四月都有国际风筝会[#]，世界各地的人都来这里放风筝。”小雪这才知道，原来潍坊有一个名字，叫“世界风筝都”。

† 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite
‡ 细 *xì* thin
§ 竹条 *zhútiáo* bamboo strip
¶ 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
* 潍坊 *Wéifāng* Weifang, a city in Shandong
风筝会 *fēngzhenghuì* kite festival

She stopped dead. The room was just like a shop! On the walls, on the table, on the floor, there were kites everywhere. There were red fish, yellow dragons and blue birds, and one huge bird whose eyes seemed to be watching her. On the table lay lots of thin bamboo strips, a few sheets of paper and some paints. 3

"Did you make all these?" asked Xiaoxue. "I made every one," said Grandpa. "I worked in a kite factory for forty years, and since I retired I still make them every day." "You make so many. Do you sell them?" "I don't sell them, I give them away," said Grandpa. "Everyone in Weifang loves kites. Since 1984 there has been an international kite festival here every April, and people come from all over the world to fly kites." Only then did Xiaoxue learn that Weifang has another name: "the kite capital of the world". 4

爷爷的风筝[†]

5 “爷爷，我也想放风筝！”小雪[‡]拿起一条红色的鱼。爷爷把鱼从她手里拿了回来，轻轻地挂回墙上。“这些是别人要的。你想放，就自己做一个。”“自己做？太麻烦了。”小雪拿出手机，“网上二十块钱就能买一个，明天就送到。”

6 爷爷说：“买的风筝也能飞，可是飞不高，也飞不好。只有自己做的风筝，才飞得最好。”“为什么？”“风筝跟人一样。只有你懂它，它才听你的。”小雪没听懂，可是她太无聊[§]了，就说：“好吧，那我做一只燕子[¶]。”爷爷点了点头：“好。燕子样子简单，又好看，很多人做的第一个风筝就是燕子。”

† 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite
‡ 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
§ 无聊 *wúliáo* boring
¶ 燕子 *yànzi* swallow (bird)

Grandpa's Kites

"Grandpa, I want to fly a kite too!" Xiaoxue picked up a red fish. Grandpa took the fish back out of her hands and gently hung it up on the wall again. "These are for other people. If you want to fly one, make one yourself." "Make one myself? That's too much trouble." Xiaoxue took out her phone. "You can buy one online for twenty yuan, and it'll be delivered tomorrow." 5

Grandpa said, "Bought kites can fly too, but not high and not well. Only a kite you make yourself flies best." "Why?" "Kites are like people. Only when you understand them will they do what you ask." Xiaoxue didn't understand, but she was so bored that she said, "All right, then I'll make a swallow." Grandpa nodded. "Good. A swallow is a simple shape and it looks nice. For lots of people, the first kite they make is a swallow." 6

7 爷爷告诉她，做风筝[1]有四步：扎[2]、糊[3]、绘[4]、放。第一步是做骨架[5]。爷爷拿出一把小刀，把一段竹子[6]分成很多很细[7]的竹条[8]。然后，他拿着竹条，放在火上慢慢地热一热。“竹子热了，就能弯[9]；冷了，它就不会再变了。”竹条在爷爷手里，很快就变成了燕子[10]的翅膀[11]。

8 小雪[12]也试了试，可是竹条到了她手里，一弯就断了。她又试了一次，又断了。“这简直是不可能的！”她大声说。“别急。”爷爷说，“我第一次做的时候，断了三十多次。”小雪用了三天，终于做好了一个燕子的骨架。骨架不太好看，可是她很满意。

9 接下来是糊纸。爷爷说，做风筝的纸要又轻又结实。

1 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite
2 扎 *zā* to build (the frame)
3 糊 *hú* to paste (paper on)
4 绘 *huì* to paint
5 骨架 *gǔjià* frame, skeleton
6 竹子 *zhúzi* bamboo
7 细 *xì* thin
8 竹条 *zhútiáo* bamboo strip
9 弯 *wān* to bend
10 燕子 *yànzi* swallow (bird)
11 翅膀 *chìbǎng* wing
12 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue

Grandpa told her that making a kite has four steps: building the frame, pasting on the paper, painting, and flying. The first step was making the frame. Grandpa took out a small knife and split a length of bamboo into lots of thin strips. Then he slowly warmed the strips over a flame. "When bamboo is warm, it will bend. When it cools, it won't change any more." In Grandpa's hands, the strips soon became a swallow's wings. 7

Xiaoxue tried too, but as soon as she bent a strip, it snapped. She tried again, and it snapped again. "This is simply impossible!" she said loudly. "Don't get upset," said Grandpa. "The first time I did it, I broke them more than thirty times." It took Xiaoxue three days, but at last she finished a swallow frame. It wasn't very pretty, but she was very pleased with it. 8

Next came pasting on the paper. Grandpa said that kite paper has to be light and strong at the same time. 9

9 小雪[1]把纸小心地贴[2]在竹条[3]上，一点儿一点儿地，用了一个下午。最后是画。她拿着笔，给燕子[4]画了黑色的翅膀[5]、白色的身体和一双大大的眼睛。左边的翅膀上，她还画了一朵[6]很大的红花。爷爷看了，说："画得不错。可是你看，左边比右边多了那么多颜色。""多一点儿颜色，有什么关系？"小雪说。爷爷笑了，没有回答。

第一次

10 第二天下午有风，爷爷带小雪到河边去放风筝[7]。小雪拿着燕子往前跑，爷爷在后面放线。风一来，燕子就飞了起来。"飞了！飞了！"小雪高兴得跳了起来。可是燕子飞了没多高，就开始往左边倒。它在天上转了几下，然后很快地掉了下来，重重地打在地上。

1 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
2 贴 *tiē* to stick
3 竹条 *zhútiáo* bamboo strip
4 燕子 *yànzi* swallow (bird)
5 翅膀 *chìbǎng* wing
6 朵 *duǒ* (measure word for flowers)
7 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite

Xiaoxue carefully stuck the paper onto the bamboo strips, bit by bit, and it took her a whole afternoon. Last came the painting. Holding a brush, she gave the swallow black wings, a white body and a pair of big eyes. On the left wing she also painted a large red flower. Grandpa looked at it and said, "Nicely painted. But look, the left side has so much more paint than the right." "What difference does a bit more paint make?" said Xiaoxue. Grandpa smiled and didn't answer. 9

The First Time

The next afternoon there was a wind, and Grandpa took Xiaoxue down to the river to fly her kite. Xiaoxue ran forward holding the swallow, while Grandpa let out the line behind her. As soon as the wind came, the swallow rose into the air. "It's flying! It's flying!" Xiaoxue jumped for joy. But the swallow hadn't flown very high before it began to tip to the left. It spun round a few times in the sky, then dropped fast and hit the ground hard. 10

11 小雪[†]跑过去一看，左边翅膀[‡]的竹条[§]断了，纸也破了。她三天的工作，一下就没有了。小雪快哭了：“我早就说要买一个！网上的风筝[¶]简直比这个好多了！”她放下破燕子[*]，一个人跑回了家。

12 那天晚上，小雪只吃了几口饭。爷爷什么也没说，拿起那只破燕子，放在了小屋子的桌子上。半夜，小雪起来喝水，看见小屋子的灯还亮着。她走到门口，看见爷爷手里拿着一只很旧很旧的燕子，上面的颜色已经快看不见了。“这是我做的第一个风筝。”爷爷说，“那年我十岁，是我爸爸教我做的。它也掉下来过很多次。”

13 “后来呢？”小雪问。“后来我才明白，风筝掉下来，常常不是风的问题，是因为它左边和右边不一样重。”小雪想起了那朵[#]大红花。“所以，我的燕子才一直往左边倒？”

† 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
‡ 翅膀 *chìbǎng* wing
§ 竹条 *zhútiáo* bamboo strip
¶ 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite
* 燕子 *yànzi* swallow (bird)
朵 *duǒ* (measure word for flowers)

Xiaoxue ran over to look. The bamboo in the left wing was broken, and the paper was torn. Three days of work, gone in a moment. Xiaoxue was close to tears. "I said all along I should buy one! The kites online are way better than this!" She dropped the broken swallow and ran home by herself. 11

That evening Xiaoxue only ate a few mouthfuls. Grandpa said nothing. He picked up the broken swallow and laid it on the table in his little room. In the middle of the night Xiaoxue got up for a drink of water and saw that the light in the little room was still on. She went to the door and saw Grandpa holding a very, very old swallow, its colours almost too faded to see. "This is the first kite I ever made," said Grandpa. "I was ten that year, and my father taught me how. It fell out of the sky plenty of times too." 12

"And then what?" asked Xiaoxue. "Later I understood: when a kite falls, it's often not the wind's fault. It's because its left side and right side aren't the same weight." Xiaoxue remembered the big red flower. "So that's why my swallow kept tipping to the left?" 13

13 爷爷笑了：“你看，你自己找到原因了。只有知道它为什么掉下来，你才能让它飞上去。”

在天上

14 从那天起，小雪[†]很少看手机了。她和爷爷一起修好了燕子[‡]的翅膀[§]，换了新纸，又把那朵[¶]红花画在了燕子的身体中间。每天下午，她都去河边试。燕子有时候飞得很高，有时候还是会掉下来。可是每一次，她都知道应该改哪儿。八月快结束的时候，燕子终于在天上飞了二十分钟，一次也没有掉下来。可是小雪也该回北京了。走的那天，爷爷说：“明年四月风筝会[*]，带着你的燕子回来。”

15 第二年四月，小雪真的回来了，爸爸妈妈也跟着来了。

† 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
‡ 燕子 *yànzi* swallow (bird)
§ 翅膀 *chìbǎng* wing
¶ 朵 *duǒ* (measure word for flowers)
* 风筝会 *fēngzhenghuì* kite festival

Grandpa smiled. "You see, you found the reason yourself. Only when you know why it fell can you make it fly." 13

In the Sky

From that day on, Xiaoxue hardly looked at her phone. She and Grandpa mended the swallow's wing and put on new paper, and this time she painted the red flower in the middle of the swallow's body. Every afternoon she went down to the river to try it. Sometimes the swallow flew high, and sometimes it still fell. But every time, she knew what to fix. As August was ending, the swallow at last flew for twenty minutes without falling once. But it was time for Xiaoxue to go back to Beijing. On the day she left, Grandpa said, "Next April, for the kite festival, bring your swallow back." 14

The following April Xiaoxue really did come back, and her parents came with her. 15

15 风筝会[†]那天，城外的大广场上人山人海[‡]。天上有几千个风筝[§]：有长长的龙，有大大的鱼，还有很多小雪[¶]叫不出名字的。很多外国游客也带来了自己国家的风筝。

16 小雪拿出了她的燕子[*]。它不大，也不是最漂亮的，翅膀[#]上还能看出修过的地方。风来了。小雪一放手，燕子就飞了上去，越飞越高。旁边一个外国小男孩用中文问她："这是你买的吗？""不是，是我自己做的！"小雪大声说。看着天上的燕子，她想：只有自己做过一次，才知道天上的每一个风筝都不容易。

17 爷爷站在她旁边，看着天上，笑着说："你的燕子，飞得简直比我的还好。"小雪也笑了。她知道，这不是真的。可是那天，在几千个风筝中间，她只看见了自己的那一只。

† 风筝会 *fēngzhenghuì* kite festival
‡ 人山人海 *rénshān rénhǎi* huge crowds of people
§ 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite
¶ 小雪 *Xiǎoxuě* Xiaoxue
* 燕子 *yànzi* swallow (bird)
\# 翅膀 *chìbǎng* wing

On the day of the kite festival, the big field outside town was packed with people. There were thousands of kites in the sky: long dragons, big fish, and many more that Xiaoxue couldn't name. Many visitors from abroad had brought kites from their own countries, too. 15

Xiaoxue took out her swallow. It wasn't big, and it wasn't the prettiest, and you could still see where the wing had been mended. The wind came. The moment Xiaoxue let go, the swallow went up, higher and higher. A little foreign boy beside her asked her in Chinese, "Did you buy that?" "No, I made it myself!" Xiaoxue said loudly. Watching the swallow in the sky, she thought: only once you have made one yourself do you know that every kite up there was hard work. 16

Grandpa stood beside her, looking up at the sky, and said with a smile, "Your swallow flies even better than mine." Xiaoxue laughed too. She knew it wasn't true. But that day, among thousands of kites, the only one she saw was her own. 17